

State Review Learnings:

Harding University

Traditional Route

On-Site Review: September 24–25, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

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Overall Performance Level		
MEETS		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS

Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion

Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	MEETS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Harding University's traditional EPP has grown its enrollment meeting the state target and effectively supports its students to complete the program.		

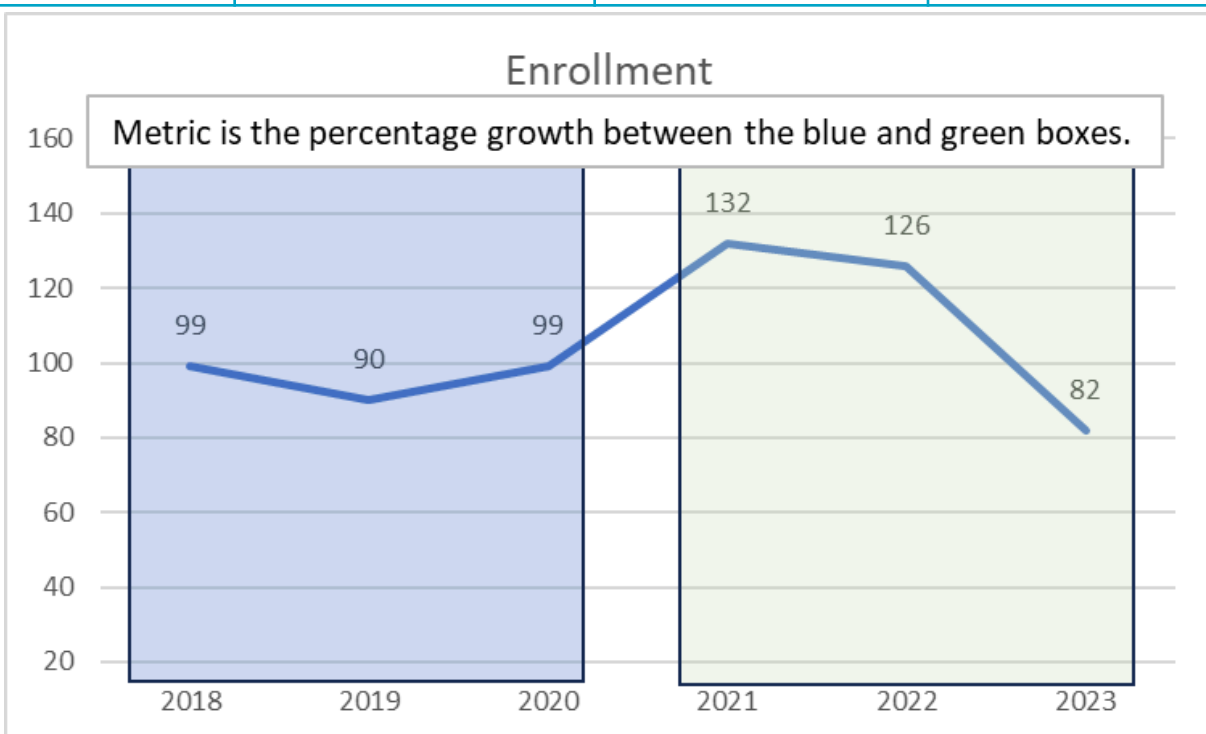
INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	Harding has a solid traditional program with a focus on improving education at both the state and national level

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs

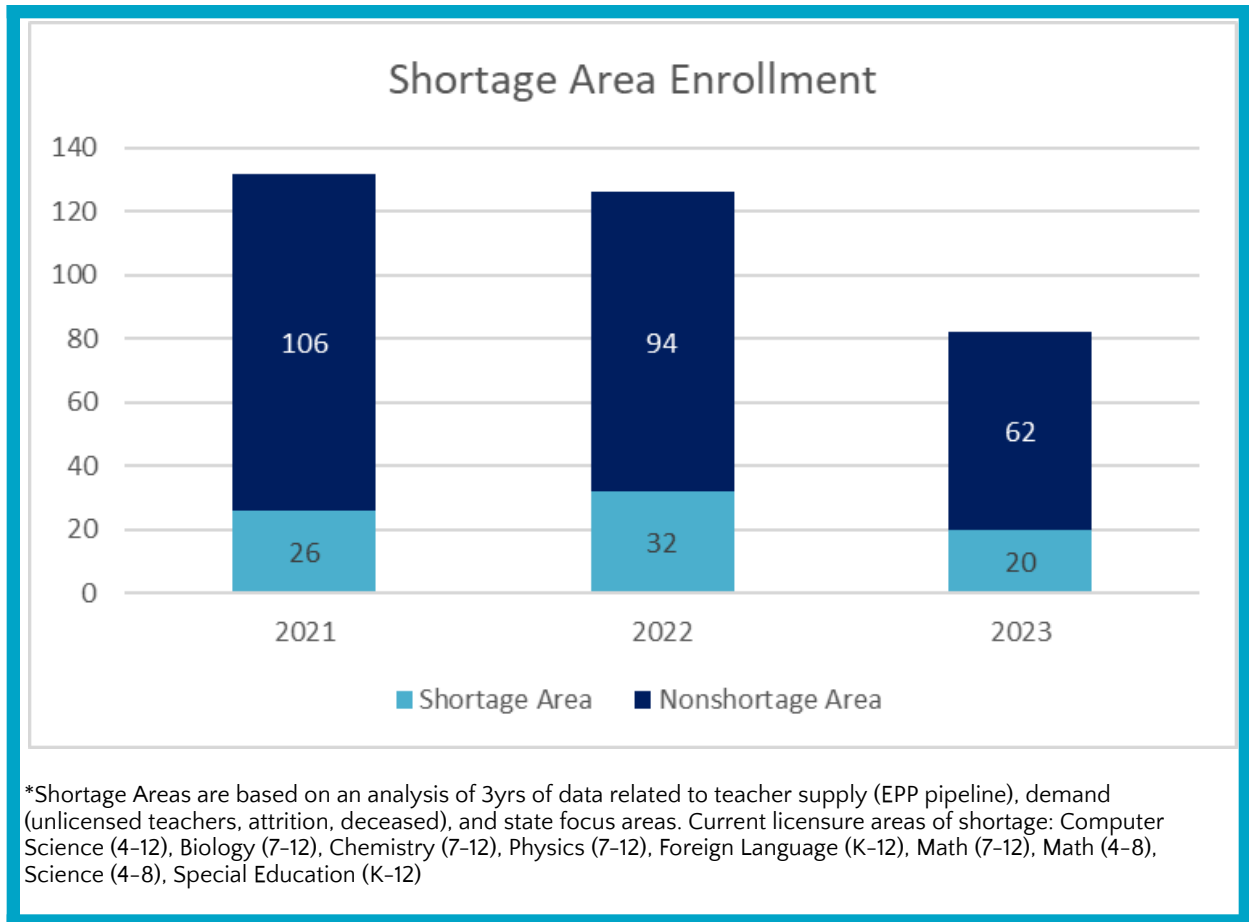
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	18.1%	EXCEEDS



*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

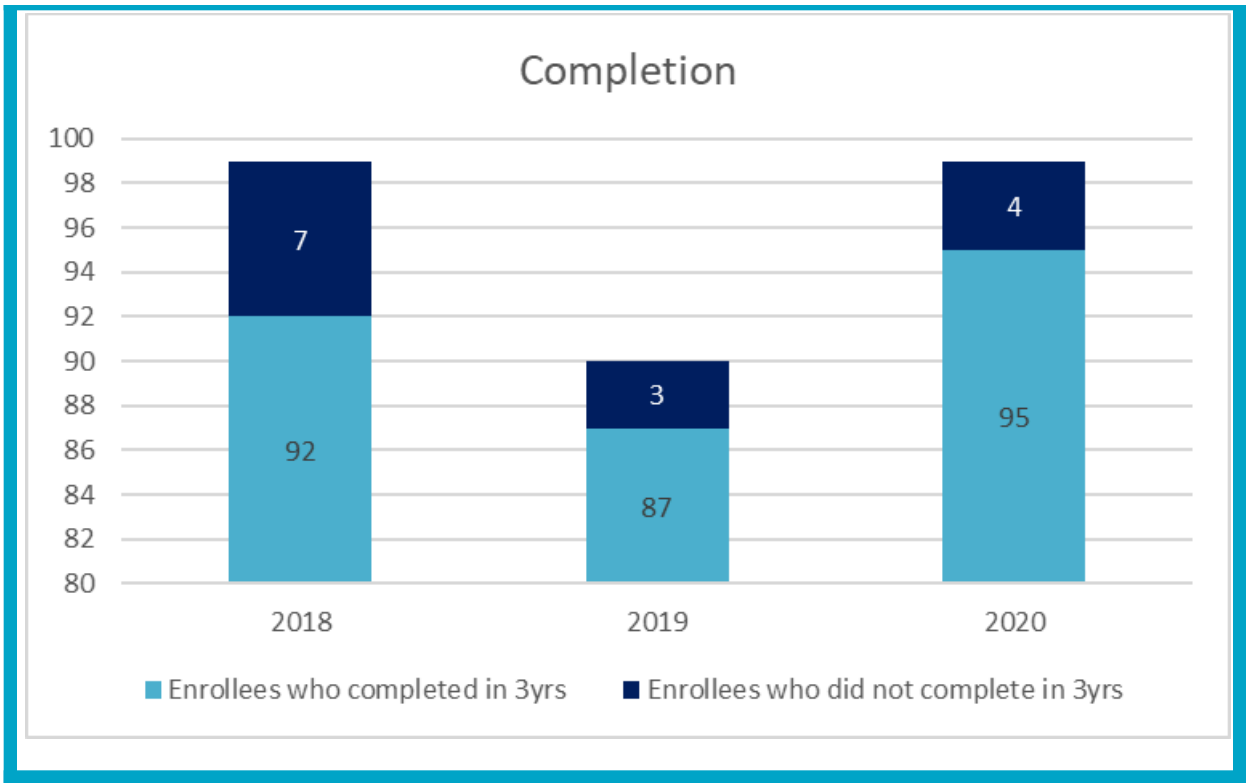
Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need

Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	23%	MEETS



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	95%	EXCEEDS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
Recommendations		
The traditional program at Harding University provided evidence to highlight their commitment to prepare teacher candidates to be day-one ready and provide continual support and feedback. Course instructors and clinical supervisors are a strength at Harding and have strengthened their collaboration with school partners to design clinical experiences. Harding utilizes best practices, Arkansas Teaching Standards and HQIM to prepare candidates, and has developed processes for annual evaluation to continually improve their programs. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: Revise clinical internship goals and milestones and ensure they are communicated to all candidates, course instructors, clinical supervisors and experienced mentor teachers (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.3b, Metric 1</i>)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
MEETS
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction EXCEEDS Coursework across the program intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices in content instruction, including the use of high-quality instructional materials (HQIM) and evidence-based strategies. During the document review, reviewers noted specific examples, such as in EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching). The course texts include the Danielson Framework, Classroom Instruction That Works (ASCD), and Checking for Understanding (ASCD), which reflect best practices in pedagogy and formative assessment. In RDNG 3120 (Foundations of Reading), the required readings emphasize the Science of Reading (SOR), including Arkansas RISE resources. The course outline directly connects content to HQIM competencies. In SEED 4140/4141 (Learning Environments and Experiences), texts such as the Danielson Framework, Marzano's New Art and Science of Teaching, and Fisher & Frey's ASCD resources demonstrate strong alignment with best practices. The Syllabus Tracker Matrix confirmed that evidence-based practices are embedded throughout the program. In the Coursework focus group, five of eight participants described how HQIM was consistently integrated across their courses. Students frequently referenced annotating lesson plans, evaluating HQIM (e.g., Wit & Wisdom, UFLI), and critiquing lessons for effectiveness. One participant highlighted the connection between coursework and practice. They said, "In foundation class, I can see how my mentor's teaching matches what we learned—they prepared us well." In the Course Instructor focus group, all participants agreed, and five of the eleven faculty members explained how HQIM is introduced early in the coursework and progressively developed. Students begin by learning what HQIM is, then annotate lessons, adapt Tier 1 and Tier 2 materials for diverse learners, and practice teaching in class before applying these skills in fieldwork. Faculty described modeling Gradual Release of Responsibility with HQIM and

literacy instruction, alongside strategies such as peer teaching, collaborative projects, and inquiry-based learning. Faculty also emphasized that HQIM mastery is a key program assessment, required before students advance to residency. Program decisions align with district adoptions, with UFLI and Wit & Wisdom used in the traditional program and CKLA in the degree-completion program.

Specific evidence of best practices was also found in course observations. In EDFE 2020 (The Teaching Profession), instruction intentionally activated prior knowledge and linked student-created classroom indicators to the Danielson Framework. The class balanced large- and small-group discussion, with a clear focus on Danielson's domains. In EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching), the instructor modeled HQIM-based strategies, using a KWL chart as a formative tool to activate prior knowledge. The class discussion highlighted how HQIM aligns with state standards, supports novice teachers, and provides vetted, consistent resources. Students engaged in reflective discussion around these materials, reinforcing their role in evidence-based practice.

Supplemental evidence was provided to show a system for annual evaluation and continuous improvement for best practices around content instruction.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
MEETS

Coursework clearly and intentionally familiarizes candidates with the Arkansas K–12 Academic Standards across all grade bands within the licensure area.

The Syllabus Tracker showed consistent evidence of standards integration throughout the program. Examples include EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching), in which assignments require candidates to review Arkansas Academic Standards across three grade levels, identify vertical alignment, and connect standards to lesson plans. A year-long Pacing Guide assignment reinforces the idea that standards shape curriculum planning. In Residency, the required lesson plan format explicitly includes “Alignment to Previous and Future Grade Level Standards,” ensuring candidates apply vertical integration in practice.

In the Coursework focus group, six of eight participants provided specific examples of how Arkansas standards are embedded throughout their coursework. Candidates consistently noted that “almost all projects start with the standards.” One explained, “In all my classes so far, we’re given standards, we break them down, and connect them to content in that class.” Another emphasized vertical alignment, noting how they examined similarities and progression of standards from younger to older grades. All candidates agreed that the standards are consistently present across the curriculum.

In the Course Instructor focus group, faculty confirmed intentional integration of Arkansas standards. In EDFD 3110, teacher candidates select a grade level and content area, unpack standards for that year, and create pacing guides. They then design lesson plans that include vertical alignment, explicitly linking standards from prior grades and preparing for subsequent grades. Faculty also cited the Residency POP Cycle, where formal lesson plans require explicit documentation of standards alignment, reinforcing both practice and accountability.

Coursework not only introduces candidates to Arkansas standards but also provides structured opportunities to vertically integrate them across grade bands. In EDFD 3110, the Vertical Alignment Analysis Assignment requires reviewing three grade levels and multiple standards, all connected to a candidate’s lesson plan. The Pacing Guide Assignment involves developing a year-long plan aligning content with Arkansas standards. During residency, the lesson plan template requires candidates to align objectives with both previous and future grade-level standards, thereby reinforcing their understanding of vertical integration and progression.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
EXCEEDS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
EXCEEDS

Courses are clearly and intentionally sequenced to build upon prior learning, provide opportunities for reinforcement, and progressively increase rigor. The “COED Degree Completion Handbook” and program checksheets provide clear guidance on course sequencing. Foundational courses, such as The Teaching Profession and Child and Adolescent Development, are taken before Principles of Learning and Teaching, Teaching the Child with Exceptionalities, and most content-area courses (e.g., K–6, Middle Level). These are completed before admission to the program. Advanced courses—such as Curriculum Design and Assessment and Learning Environments—are taken after admission and provide deeper application. The residency year builds directly on these courses, requiring candidates to demonstrate

mastery in authentic classroom settings. In secondary programs, the sequence is more compact, but the same structure applies: foundational courses (e.g., The Teaching Profession, Child and Adolescent Development) are taken before Principles of Learning and Teaching, while courses such as Exceptional Child are completed after admission.

In the Coursework focus group, teaching candidates affirmed that the program is intentionally scaffolded. One explained, “You learn content first, then the next class is how to apply it.” Another student who switched majors experienced courses out of sequence and acknowledged that this disrupted the intended progression: “I’ve taken these classes in different orders... it would have been better to follow the sequence because they do build on each other.” Overall, participants agreed that the program builds systematically across coursework.

In the Course Instructor focus group, faculty confirmed that coursework is deliberately designed to move from theory to practice. One course instructor outlined the sequence, “in EDFE 2020 (Intro Course), students choose a standard, plan a mini-lesson, and practice unpacking it. Then in their next courses, candidates build on these skills, working in groups, annotating HQIM, and implementing practices in the field.” The faculty described this as a progression from knowledge acquisition to application. One participant shared, “We moved away from just knowledge to practice.” Another emphasized increasing rigor, noting that in Residency, candidates are required to substitute teach in multiple grade levels, which demands readiness, adaptability, and effectiveness. The program incorporates multiple reinforcement opportunities and emphasizes mastery of skills. Key assessments throughout the sequence require candidates to demonstrate competency before they can advance. In Residency, candidates must demonstrate mastery of the required competencies; only then can they progress, ensuring that rigor increases across the program and culminates in applied, high-stakes practice.

Supplemental evidence was provided to show a system for annual evaluation and continuous improvement for the sequence and progression of courses.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework
EXCEEDS

Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned with clinical experiences, providing consistent opportunities for candidates to connect their coursework to practice. The “Traditional Program Syllabi Tracker” shows that course objectives are aligned to Arkansas Educator Competencies in courses such as ECED 3100 (Foundations of Early Childhood), SPED 3030 (Teaching Students with Exceptionalities), MATH 2231 (Math Applications for P-8 Teachers), and ELED/MLED 3200 (Interdisciplinary Approach to Teaching Arkansas History). Course assignments also demonstrate alignment. For example, RDNG 3120 (Foundations of Reading) incorporates Arkansas Educator Competencies, while EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching), ELED/MLED 3200, and SEED 4140/4141 (Learning Environments and Experiences) provide explicit links to the Arkansas Teaching Standards within their objectives and assignments.

Students described multiple opportunities to connect coursework with practical experiences. Three participants working in after-school programs reported that content from courses such as Classroom Management directly supported their effectiveness in those roles. Others explained that early observations embedded in coursework (e.g., observing and analyzing developmental stages, followed by writing reflection papers) provided opportunities to apply course knowledge to real-world contexts. Although not all students had reached Residency, they affirmed that coursework-to-practice connections were visible and reinforced across classes.

Faculty confirmed that the program was intentionally designed to align coursework with clinical expectations. One instructor explained: “We sat around the table with the standards and placed them across courses—teaching one aspect in an introductory class, then addressing it more deeply in a later course. We designed it with scope and sequence in mind.” Another faculty member highlighted literacy preparation, describing how backward design from the Arkansas Teaching Standards shaped coursework and was made explicit to students, helping them recognize the connection between standards, assignments, and clinical practice.

During course observations, reviewers noted that while explicit references to Arkansas Educator Competencies and Teaching Standards were not always made in class, alignment was evident in practice. Examples included lessons focused on the Science of Reading, activities using HQIM, and discussions of ATR content—all of which reflected direct application of standards to instructional preparation.

Supplemental evidence was provided to show a system for annual evaluation and continuous improvement for the utilization of Arkansas Teaching Standards.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience

MEETS

Coursework is intentionally aligned to clinical experiences, with structured opportunities for candidates to reflect on and apply what they are learning. The “Syllabi Tracker” identifies courses that explicitly connect to field experiences. The “HQIM Matrix” highlights the connections between coursework and clinical application. In ECED 3100 (Foundations of Early Childhood), candidates volunteer at an ELL/Migrant family event and complete a reflection on engaging with children and families. The POP cycle paperwork requires candidates to reflect on what was taught in their placements and identify “Which courses/topics have you drawn from to assist you with your development and experience in your classroom?”

Faculty described intentional alignment between coursework and clinical practice. In literacy and intervention courses taken alongside Residency, candidates apply coursework directly in the field. For example, in one intervention course, candidates select a student, conduct pre- and post-assessments, and provide at least 20 intervention sessions. Each class meeting begins with a reflection on what candidates observe in their placement and how it connects to course content. In EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching), candidates analyze the four domains of the Arkansas Teacher Rubric (ATR). Faculty guide them in mapping where each domain is taught across the program and how coursework supports their field preparation.

Reviewers observed evidence of intentional alignment in multiple courses. In EDFD 3110 (Principles of Learning and Teaching), coursework mirrored classroom practice through the use of HQIM. Candidates engaged in a KWL activity to model how HQIM activates prior knowledge, aligning with strategies used in real classrooms. Reflection activities included evaluating HQIM materials using the DESE state guide and EdReports, as well as reinforcing connections between coursework, standards, and fieldwork. Candidates also collaborated to summarize HQIM competencies with graphic organizers, building both content knowledge and reflective practice skills. In EDFD 2020 (The Teaching Profession), an introductory course, students did not yet reflect back on clinical practice but were consistently asked to look ahead to future experiences. The instructor connected lessons to Residency expectations, particularly the ATR/Danielson rubric. Students were asked to identify which domain might be most challenging for them, encouraging early reflection on areas for growth. The syllabus also outlined pathways for completing observation hours, including classroom settings, tutoring, and non-paid K–12 instructional experiences.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors demonstrate deep knowledge of Arkansas K–12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. Faculty rosters provided by the EPP show that nearly all full-time and adjunct instructors hold at least a master’s degree, with many holding terminal degrees and over 18 graduate hours in their discipline or subfield. Harding’s “Faculty Spreadsheet” lists 18 of 21 education faculty members with terminal degrees, and 10 of 13 faculty profiles confirm ongoing engagement in professional development aligned with DESE initiatives, such as Aspiring Teacher, Coaching, and HQIM training, since 2024. All faculty and adjuncts also bring prior PK–12 teaching experience, further strengthening their instructional expertise.

Candidate feedback reinforced that faculty demonstrate expertise in both standards and pedagogy. In focus groups, students described faculty as passionate and effective in modeling instructional practices. One candidate explained that a literacy professor “teaches us a concept—she is a teacher doing the concept with us, she models what it looks like and then brings in skills and lots of examples.” Another noted how faculty connected candidate responses to future classroom experiences: “When she models, we respond to the content, and she helps us see that our students will respond differently too.” In mathematics, candidates valued faculty who modeled multiple solution strategies and encouraged deeper understanding: “She would give several ways to solve problems, then build on them.” These comments illustrate faculty members’ ability to model effective pedagogy and connect theory to practice in meaningful ways.

Classroom observations also confirmed that faculty bring strong knowledge of Arkansas standards and pedagogy into their instruction. In Teaching Young Writers (ELED 3170), the instructor consistently connected lessons to the Science of Reading and ELA standards, linking candidate responses back to standards-based content. In Principles of Learning and Teaching (EDFD 3110), reviewers observed instructions that reflected a deep knowledge of standards and pedagogy, even when the standards were not explicitly named. The instructor modeled the use of HQIM through a KWL activity, emphasizing how aligned, high-quality resources support new teachers. Candidates received DESE handouts on HQIM competencies and practiced evaluating materials. Academic vocabulary was consistently reinforced, and candidates engaged in small groups to create graphic organizers of HQIM competencies. All students were actively participating, and the session included discussions of differentiation, assessment, classroom management, and inclusion. These observations demonstrate that faculty not only hold deep content and pedagogical knowledge but also model effective instructional practices that prepare candidates for classroom application.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors have a proven history of strong facilitation of coursework and consistently provide feedback and support to candidates. Course evaluations from Spring 2025 provide additional evidence of faculty effectiveness. Response rates ranged from just under half of a class to as low as 10 percent. Across these courses, overall ratings related to faculty impact on student learning were 4.0 or higher on a five-point scale, with the only rating below a 4.0 coming from the course with the lowest response rate. Annual faculty evaluations also include a process of self-reflection and supervisor response, addressing teaching, scholarship, and service. While these evaluations are university-wide and not specific to the EPP, they provide an additional structure for ensuring accountability and improvement in instruction.

Evidence from syllabi further demonstrates faculty commitment to accessibility and support. Instructors provide email, office phone, and often cell phone numbers, and many list multiple times each week when they are available to meet with students. Candidate comments reinforced this accessibility and the quality of feedback provided. One student explained that when they were unsure of what to do, a faculty member responded promptly by reviewing lesson plans and offering constructive guidance, keeping the candidate on track. Another piece of recalled feedback was provided after the Pearson Reading exam, noting that the instructor identified areas of struggle and offered hands-on feedback beyond the scope of the coursework. Candidates also shared that faculty provided personal support during challenging times, such as when a student had a family member in the hospital. Across focus groups, students consistently emphasized that faculty were approachable, responsive, and supportive, creating a safe and comfortable environment for asking questions.

Reviewers observed evidence of strong facilitation and support in all four course observations. Faculty engaged candidates through discussions, group work, and active participation. Strategies included the use of graphic organizers, gallery walks, and color-coded feedback, all of which encouraged interaction and deeper understanding. These practices demonstrate how faculty not only impart content knowledge but also model effective facilitation strategies that candidates can apply in their own classrooms.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall sequence of clinical experiences clearly and intentionally builds upon prior experiences, providing candidates with increasing opportunities for learning and development. Adequate evidence was provided to demonstrate this progression, as evident in the sequencing of observation opportunities during the junior and senior years, and the increasingly rigorous expectations for content knowledge and application outlined in the course syllabi. Candidates begin by observing high-quality video teaching samples, then transition to field-based experiences focused on specific content areas, and ultimately advance to full Residency. Throughout this process, student progress

and achievement are tracked in Anthology, providing faculty with data to inform instructional practices and ensure that candidates are prepared for increasingly complex teaching responsibilities.

Candidates confirmed this gradual progression in both scope and rigor. One student shared an example of visiting an elementary school and teaching a single lesson to the class. Another added, "In that same class, we went to an afterschool program at a local church and taught the same lesson to a couple of groups; it had to be more of a fun activity rather than just a sit-and-get lesson." A third summarized, "Also, we got to break apart and do different grades – K, 1, 3–5, etc.; in terms of sequence it's been a gradual release – our freshman year, we had opportunities to observe, went to Little Rock and observed a whole day; we had to get a certain number of observation hours, then teach in class, and now, Residency with a full classroom."

Faculty echoed these observations, further illustrating the intentional design of the program's clinical sequence. One course instructor stated, "In my class, we build foundations and students go in the field, observe, come back and use HQIM to write a lesson to teach back in the school that coordinates with the current instruction in the classroom." Another explained, "In the introduction class, they have to observe 16 hours; we accompany them for 8. They also tour a junior high and an elementary school after hours to see how the schools are arranged and how they differ. Our whole program starts as this very wide gateway and funnels to a specific." A third faculty member emphasized the importance of contextualizing for candidates, many of whom are from outside the state: "A lot of our students are not from AR, so we want them to see what it's like in Arkansas schools and compare it to their experiences; see the reality."

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall variety of clinical experiences, aligned with the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, provides adequate opportunities for candidates to work with students who have varied learning needs. Evidence of this is seen in the diversity of placements within partner schools and the ways in which candidates are prepared through coursework to address diverse learning needs. Candidates rehearse differentiation strategies to support English language learners, students with learning disabilities, students with markers of dyslexia, and students requiring reading interventions. These strategies are then practiced in classrooms that reflect a range of demographics. The use of the Aspiring Teacher Rubric to guide all POP cycle evaluations and walk-through observations further ensures that candidates are consistently evaluated on their ability to meet varied learning needs.

Candidates described a range of experiences that provided meaningful exposure to diverse learners. One noted, "We get to sub in Residency, which opens up extra opportunities; I got to sub in a 6th grade classroom (she is typically in 4th grade) and that was a whole new experience." Another explained, "On Fridays, I'm able to sub outside of my subject area; last week I subbed in Health, then I've done English." Others highlighted the diversity within their own classrooms, with one candidate sharing, "Within the classroom that I'm in, we have students who didn't pass a single question on the ATLAS to students who did really well; watching my mentor teacher plan for that span has been really helpful; there are some 'handicaps' in the classroom, physical and mental; there's a lot of different exposure."

Course instructors confirmed that the program is intentionally structured to expand candidates' experiences with diverse learners. One faculty member explained, "Starting before Residency, we talk about sheltered instruction, and then the students go to an event hosted by the co-op in the schools to work with ESOL families. They can start to see how the relationships are built with these families and students." Another added, "We partner with Searcy so our students can substitute teach every Friday anywhere in the district, which gives them a lot of variety of placements." Coursework has also been designed to prepare students to engage with diverse populations. One instructor described, "Teacher candidates research the demographics for their classroom, school, city, and state. We do that at the beginning of Residency so they can think through potential biases, the effects of demographics on student learning, and learning needs that might vary between two settings." Faculty also described assignments that extend into family engagement, such as surveys sent home to begin building parent contacts, followed by class discussions on different approaches if families do not respond.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

Most experienced mentor teachers are equipped and demonstrate coaching skills that support candidates' pedagogical development. The "Residency Evaluation Survey" data showed that 24 of 26 candidates rated their mentors between 3 and 5, and TESS evaluations of mentor teachers were overwhelmingly rated as "Effective" or "Highly Effective". Candidates described frequent conversations and modeling from their mentor teachers, with one noting, "She makes sure she explains how she's doing it so they have a consistent method when I do it." Another shared, "My mentor teacher will teach the first class, and I will teach the second; I will observe her." Evidence also included mentor training in ATR, Science of Reading, HQIM, and, for some, Lead/Master Teacher or cognitive coaching.

Interviews with school leaders reinforced this. Both superintendents noted that many mentor teachers hold or are pursuing Lead/Master designation, with additional coaching supports offered in-house. One stated, "Many of ours have gone through cognitive coaching... we try to give them an extra skill set." Mentor feedback samples further illustrated coaching practices, with specific comments such as, "To help with syllables, clap them out," and "Make sure instruction is explicit at all times."

Note: By 2026-2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

A clear and intentional process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers based on criteria that include years of classroom experience, demonstrated instructional effectiveness, depth of content, and pedagogical knowledge. A "Residency Match Meeting" is held with HU, SSD leadership, and principals to review mentor teachers who are open to serving in the upcoming year. Handbook criteria align with state rules and are rigorous, requiring training on the ATR, Science of Reading pathway, HQIM, and pursuit of Lead or Master Teacher designation. Guidelines for mentor teachers are clearly outlined in the handbook.

District leaders confirmed that most mentor teachers hold or are working toward Lead/Master designation, and described semi-formal or informal processes for matching teacher candidates with mentors. One superintendent explained, "I'd call it semi-formal. The principals will help with a pool of potential mentor teachers, and then the university selects. We offer a small stipend. It does become a little more competitive and evaluative." Another described a more flexible approach: "I'd say ours is more informal. We seek input from the teacher who wants to be a mentor teacher. Once Harding lets us know what they're seeking, we try to match up." Both noted that stipends are tied to Master/Lead status, which applies to nearly all mentors. Building principals are responsible for evaluating mentor teachers through their regular TESS observations and for meeting with both mentors and candidates to share feedback.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Most program clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. Eleven of the twelve supervisors have coaching training, nearly all have ATR training, and they were rated as effective or above on the "Residency Evaluation Survey" for being supportive, providing constructive feedback, and helping candidates achieve their goals. Candidates consistently reported receiving frequent, written, and oral feedback from both mentor teachers and clinical supervisors that was connected to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and built on prior feedback. One candidate shared, "Every time a clinical supervisor comes in for an observation, they'll pull me aside and ask if I need anything...I feel very supported." Another explained, "My supervisor would send me her notes immediately; she's been super encouraging, she gives feedback that she knows will help me, not tear me down."

Observation of clinical supervision confirmed these practices. Supervisors employed cognitive coaching strategies, posed reflective questions, and provided targeted feedback linked to ATR and the Science of Reading. Comments such as, "You gave a really clear objective; you did a great job of setting them up for learning," and "You had the letters color-coded and it kept the pacing and engagement up," illustrate both encouragement and actionable guidance. Supervisors also reinforced the use of HQIM and SOR vocabulary, encouraging candidates to reflect on their instructional choices and student outcomes.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Program documents show that candidates receive frequent written and oral feedback from their clinical supervisors. Feedback is clearly connected to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, linked to evidence of student learning, and builds across observation cycles. Written feedback is provided on observation forms, aligned with the ATR and Danielson frameworks, and includes ratings across various domains.

Candidates confirmed that feedback from their clinical supervisors is consistent, detailed, and growth-oriented. One candidate shared, "My supervisor...submits the Google form with the feedback, schedules a meeting with me to talk about how I felt about the lesson, and asks specific questions about my decisions." Another explained, "We have to share if students grow during our post-observation conference; yes, feedback is based on all of the domains, so it builds on the previous feedback." Candidates emphasized that feedback shaped their instructional growth, particularly with the Science of Reading. As one noted, "Just knowing what the SOR is and how we know it so clearly from supervisor feedback—that has shaped my growth." Others described how supervisors required them to revise or reteach when gaps in understanding were observed, which they found helpful in preparing to meet the needs of their own students.

Site visit observations confirmed that supervisors provide high-quality, evidence-based feedback during coaching sessions. Feedback statements referenced specific examples from lessons, underscoring ATR ratings and reinforcing growth over time. One supervisor noted, "Because you knew the content so well, you could extend the learning for the students," while another emphasized planning and instructional rigor: "Your planning was appropriate not just for the students but for the scope and sequence of the curriculum and based on what students already know." Supervisors also highlighted candidate strengths, such as "I actually scored you Highly Effective on Demonstrating an Environment of Respect & Rapport," and reinforced areas for further growth.

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024-25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

MEETS

Program documents, including MOUs and email communications, demonstrate that collaborative processes are in place with districts and schools to co-construct the clinical internship. Documents show that clinical supervisors communicate performance data, provide guidance on next steps for teacher candidates, and participate in ongoing governance meetings with administrators and, when applicable, mentor teachers. Clinical supervisors are also documented as providing resources and handbooks to mentor teachers, supporting consistent expectations and guidance.

Candidates and district personnel confirmed that clinical supervisors are accessible, responsive, and integral to coordinating the clinical internship. One mentor teacher participant stated, "Our supervisor comes every other week, and we just pick a time to talk about the teacher candidate and upcoming formal observation, walk through what it will look like, bounce ideas." Another added, "All of them are quick to respond through email." District representatives noted regular communication with clinical supervisors to ensure teacher candidates are supported: "I just call them whenever I have a need because we know they are well trained and ready to go." Supervisors and districts also make adjustments based on feedback, such as modifying classroom schedules for consecutive days. All participants emphasized that clinical supervisor input is consistently heard and implemented, supporting alignment between coursework, field experience, and candidate development.

During site visit observations, clinical supervisors were seen actively coordinating with districts and teacher candidates to guide the clinical experience. Their involvement included reviewing candidate progress, suggesting next steps, and facilitating reflective discussions with teacher candidates to address observed instructional needs. Feedback loops were evident, with supervisors adjusting recommendations based on candidate performance and district context.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Program documents indicate that collaborative processes are consistently in place to support and develop clinical supervisors. Clinical supervisors participate in governance meetings with partner schools to analyze data on teacher candidates and provide input on program improvements. Professional development records show that 10 of 12 supervisors have completed coaching training, six have ATR training, and all have participated in additional PD relevant to their roles, including cognitive coaching, SOR, Aspiring Teacher, and Phonics/Foundations. Clinical supervisors also engage in calibration activities to standardize observations and feedback across the program.

Clinical supervisors reported strong alignment and collaboration among themselves. One noted, “All of us who are also course instructors were ‘on the same page’ regarding expectations, the language we use with teacher candidates in their classrooms, and the expectations for growth along the ATR, demonstrating a strong calibration to support each other as supervisors.” Participants emphasized the importance of ongoing professional development and community engagement to enhance their effectiveness. For example, one supervisor shared, “Three of us attended a forum with several panels from the community. The goal was to explore how we meet the mental health needs of our students and communities. As mentors, we want to be as informed as possible to help our candidates impact students.” Another described attending ethics briefings and national conferences, as well as reviewing trends after job fairs to inform supervision practices.

During site visit observations, supervisors were observed working collaboratively to ensure consistent guidance for candidates. They modeled calibrated practices in the classroom, applying shared language and expectations across placements. Supervisors referenced prior professional development and ongoing data analysis in guiding teacher candidates, demonstrating an integrated approach to supervision and a commitment to continuous professional growth.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Evidence demonstrates that most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. Data from the “Master Intern/Resident Spreadsheet” indicates that well above 80% of candidates maintain a 3.0 or higher GPA in both their major and cumulative coursework. The “Admission Spreadsheet” further indicates that pre-admission course grades are consistently above average, with a higher proportion of “A” and “B” grades than “C” grades. An early alert system is in place to identify struggling students, and the standing Admission & Retention Committee actively tracks performance using candidate data.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Program documents indicate that candidates are consistently provided with individualized support plans if they are not meeting coursework requirements. The “Growth Plan Form” requires candidates to reflect on their progress and document the steps they will take for improvement. Gateways are built into the program to ensure academic benchmarks are met, including course grade requirements, recommendation letters, and progress checks. If needed, academic improvement plans are initiated, requiring active participation from candidates.

The faculty described multiple structures to identify and support candidates early. One noted, “The University’s early alert program—around four to five weeks in—advisors and instructors submit concerns, which go to academic counselors for follow-up. This allows for multiple points of contact so students don’t fall too far behind.” Another explained, “The gateways provide a way to assure students remain on track. If requirements aren’t met, an academic improvement plan is developed.” Faculty also emphasized candidate involvement: “Once students are in the field,

structures are in place for a growth plan. The student is part of the process—first identifying that they are struggling and then helping develop the plan.”

During the visit, reviewers observed evidence that candidates take an active role in developing and monitoring their individualized plans. Candidates documented their reflections on progress using the “Growth Plan Form,” and faculty reinforced that progress was regularly reviewed during advising meetings.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

Program documents show that goals and milestones for the clinical internship are outlined in the “Residency Handbook,” supported by a clear progression of responsibilities, and tracked through the “Intern/Resident Spreadsheet.” POP cycles serve as structured checkpoints aligned to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric.

Although focus group responses reflected mixed clarity around program goals, program documents show candidates meet milestones such as GPA, observations, and meeting program gates. Candidates also described setting professional growth plans with their clinical supervisors, including expectations around POP cycles and mentor teacher input. Course-level goals, however, were described as very clear, with several praising the organization of class notebooks.

Observations confirmed that clinical supervisors are aligned on program goals and milestones and use the POP cycle data to track progress and growth.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

Program documents demonstrate that candidates are required to assess student learning, provide work samples, and analyze performance through pre- and post-assessments tied to targeted objectives. Data from site coordinators consistently show candidates earning ratings of 3 or higher on planning for and assessing student learning, further supporting evidence of their capacity to impact student growth.

Focus group responses confirmed that candidates engage directly with student data and instructional planning. Several described intervention projects, small group instruction, and opportunities to lead assessments, with one noting, “I did a first one with kids and a second one, so I got to see how they improved; I got to see that they were learning what I was teaching.” Candidates also highlighted working with teams to analyze scores, track progress through POP cycles, and support English learners through targeted assignments. In some cases, school leaders recognized the strength of candidates, with principals arranging for them to lead student groups and mentor others in evidence-based practices.

Observations provided further confirmation that candidates apply data to instruction and reflect on its impact. Clinical supervisors noted the candidates’ ability to design lessons around student needs, adjust instruction in real-time, and articulate strategies for improvement. One supervisor remarked, “You then circled back to him, and he showed you. That was fun to watch. I saw the light bulb go off.” Feedback consistently affirmed candidates’ effectiveness in using data-driven instruction to support student growth.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Evidence demonstrates that most candidates receive a score of “effective” on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Summary data from site coordinators indicate that mean ratings across the domains are consistently at or only slightly below effective over the last three years. Walkthrough data shows that candidates frequently score proficient/effective on most criteria.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

Most candidates with varied needs are provided with the support they require, including those who struggle, who are consistently offered an individualized support plan if their development in the clinical internship is not on track. Program documents outline performance management procedures for struggling candidates, including reflection and documentation of progress. Coaching notes confirm that supervisors provide targeted feedback and recommend strategies to address areas of need.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, responses affirmed consistent support for varied candidate needs. Several residents described their clinical supervisors as highly accessible and responsive: “Every time the clinical supervisor comes in for an observation, they’ll pull me aside and ask if I need anything...I feel very supported.” One added, “My mentor teacher was absent on my POP cycle observation, so my supervisor came to watch; it didn’t go great, but she stayed and talked with me afterward, sent me a text later; that support made me way more successful.” Faculty and supervisors also emphasized that struggling residents remain in the program with individualized attention: “We’re not running a pass-fail program. We’re running a how-can-we-get-better program.”

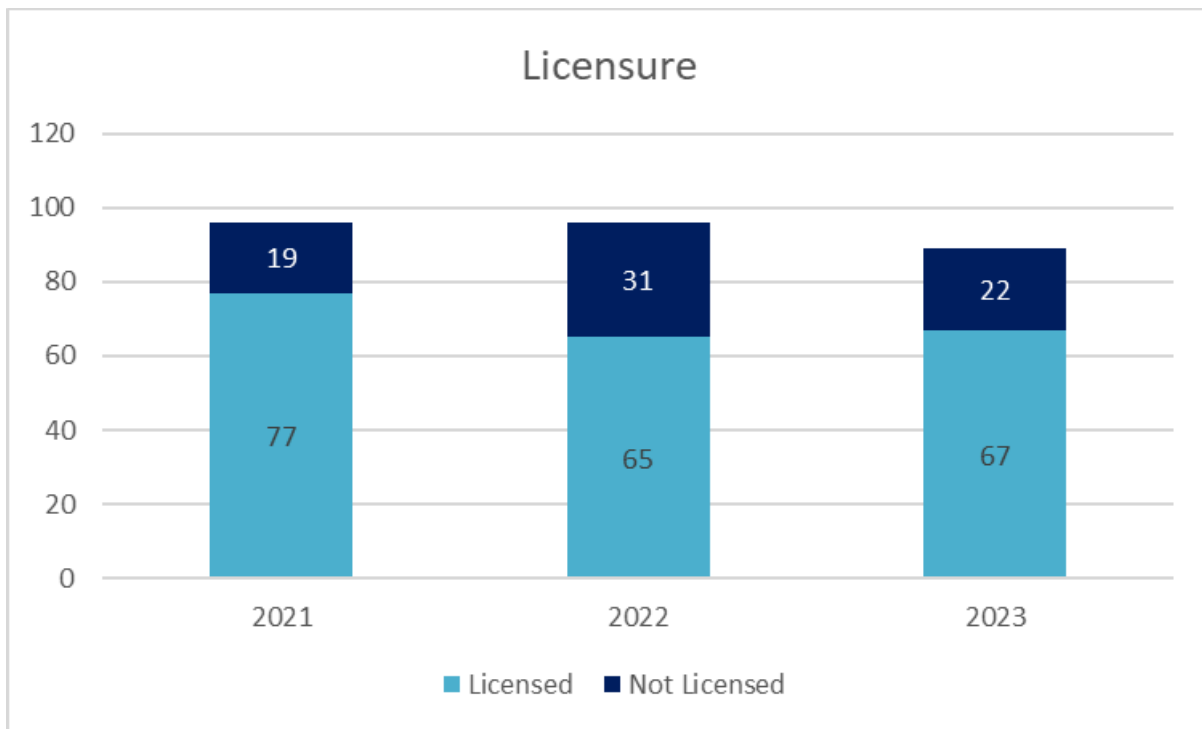
High-performing candidates also receive opportunities and recognition that support retention. Residents were encouraged to lead small groups, share videos of effective practice, and serve as models for their peers. District leaders and principals reinforced the quality of top residents by offering them additional teaching opportunities and, in some cases, direct hiring. One candidate was described as having “beat out well-experienced educators” for a position. Supervisors provided positive, specific feedback, with comments highlighting both professional growth and classroom impact.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
MEETS	BELOW	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Recommendations include: - Pursue initiatives to encourage candidates to consider high-priority subject areas and work placements once licensed. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 3.2a, 3.2b</i>) - Support program completers to work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects to increase the percentage of licensed teachers who take this type of job in the first three years after completion. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.2b</i>)		

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion	80%	74%	APPROACHING

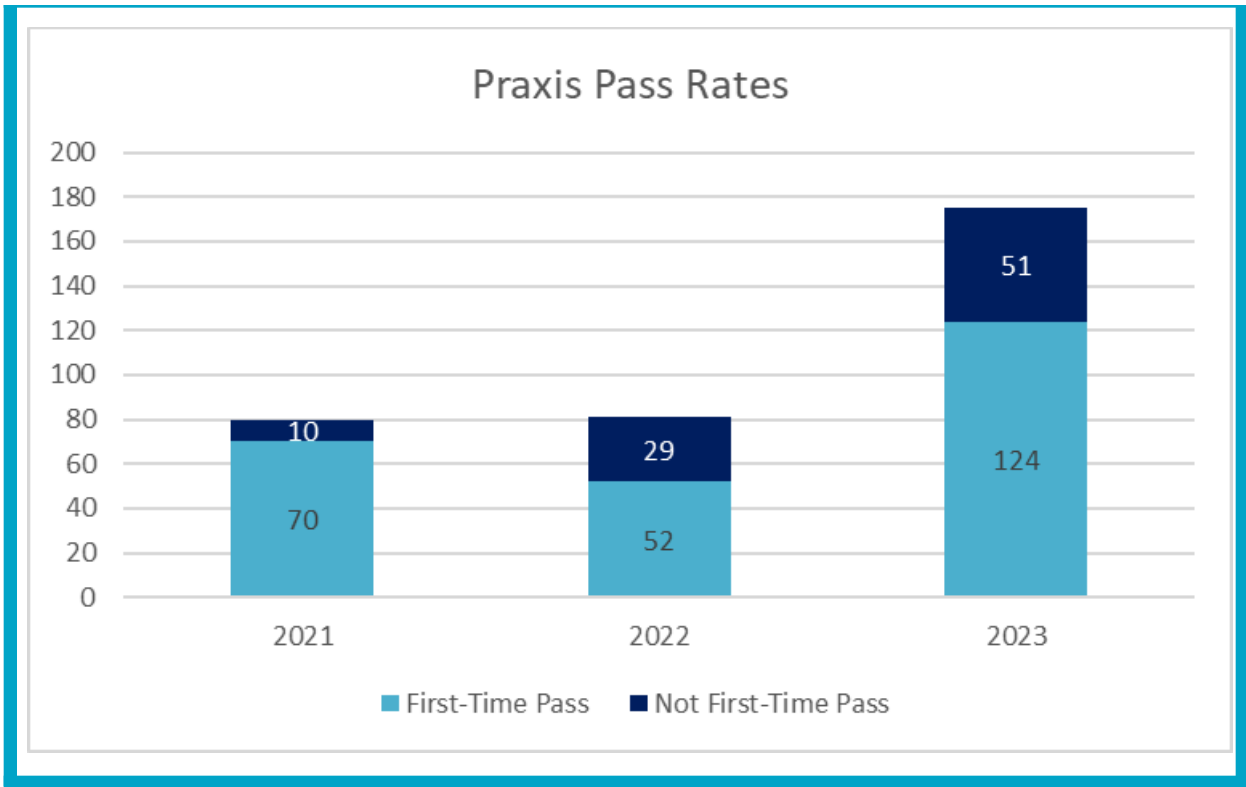


Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	N/A	N/A

Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	73.2%	EXCEEDS



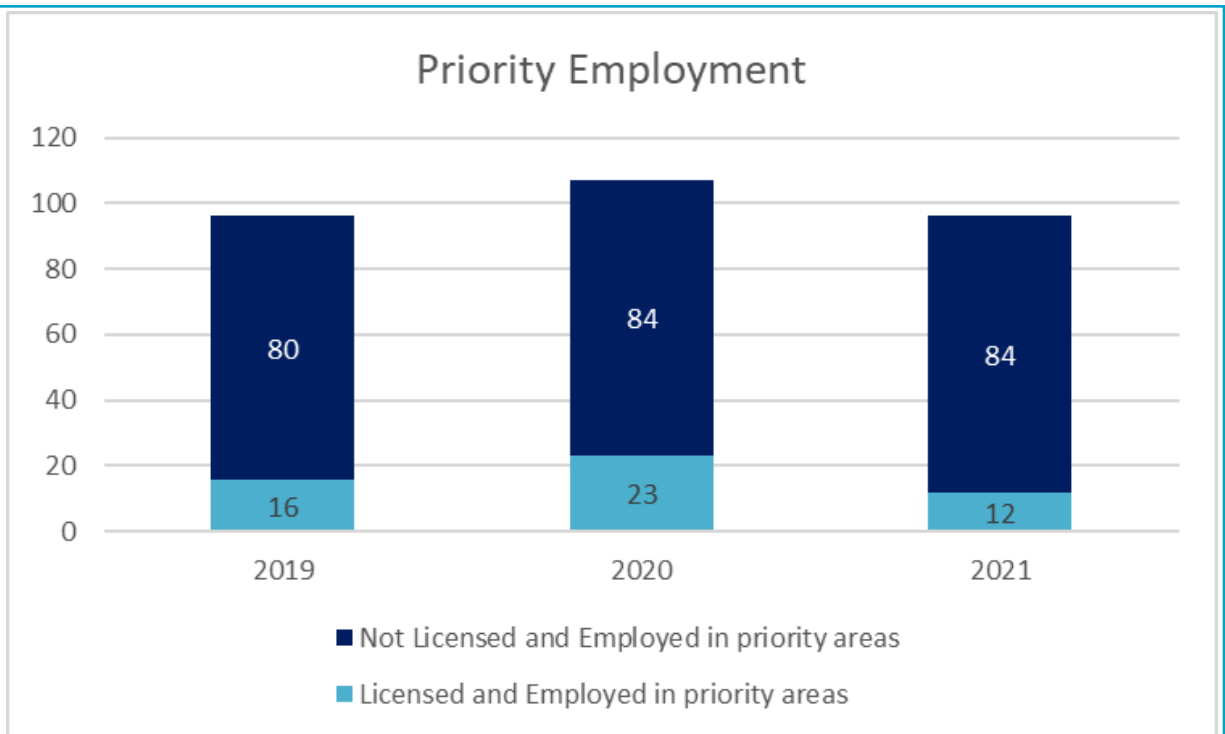
INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	38.1%	BELOW

Employment

Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed
2019	31	65
2020	42	65
2021	41	55

Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	17.1%	BELOW



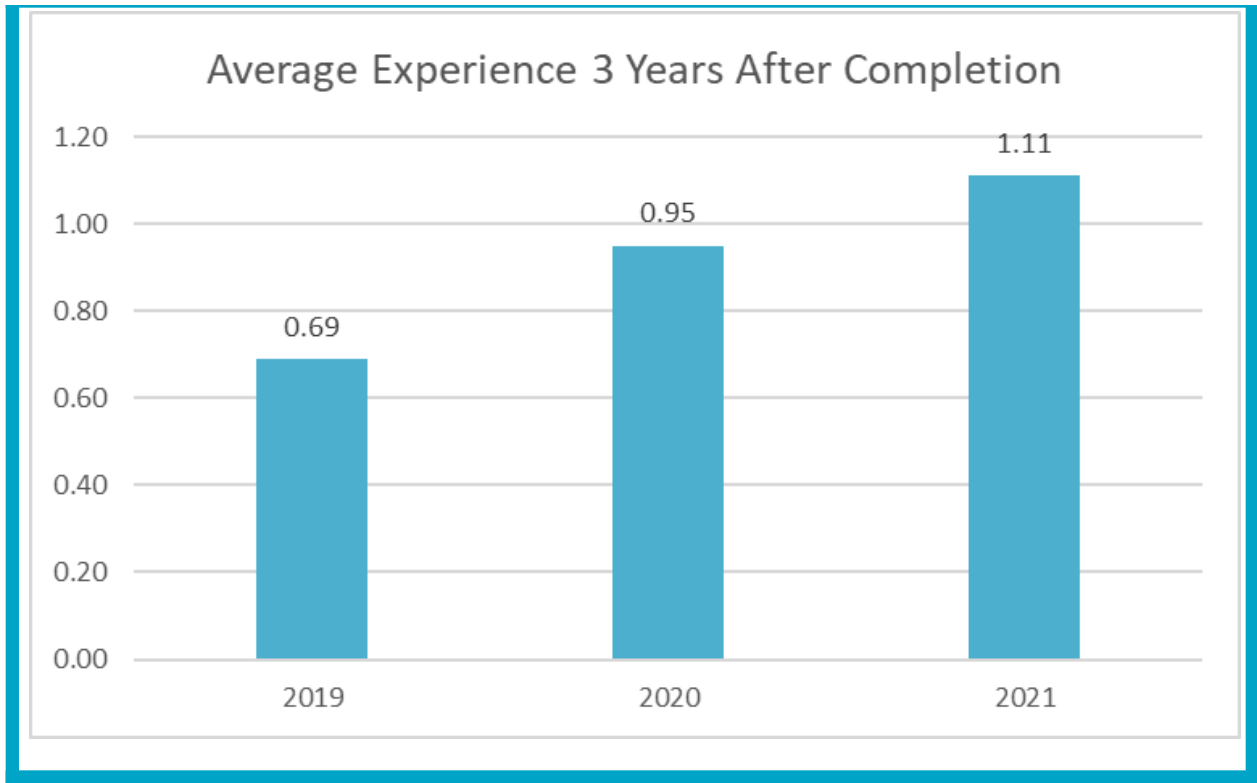
*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	.92	APPROACHING



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	92.3%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	85.2%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	48%	EXCEEDS

